KEY FEATURES AND IMPLEMENTATION PRACTICES FOR SUCCESSFUL CRM SYSTEM ADOPTION

A
PRACTICAL
GUIDE

INTRODUCTION

This is an implementation guide for customer relationship management (CRM) systems.

It presents research-based insights for the successful deployment of a minimum viable product (MVP) CRM system.

It is oriented towards the optimisation of sales processes in small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs).

It introduces key CRM system features and implementation practices, which are categorised by importance:

REQUIRED and **OPTIONAL**.

CONTEXT & MOTIVATION

While a lot of research on CRM adoption is available, academic literature appears to primarily focus on high-level, strategic considerations for large enterprises.

This guide aims to offer an alternative perspective by delivering practically applicable suggestions for small teams. Its contents are based on the thesis work as referenced below.

RESEARCH REFERENCE

Degree:
South-Eastern Finland University of Applied Sciences (XAMK), Bachelor of Culture and Arts, Game Design

Thesis title:
B2B sales process optimisation in SMEs: Designing a framework for MVP CRM systems

Author:
Martin Rodenbeck

CRM SYSTEM FEATURES

CENTRAL DATABASE

REQUIRED

OVERVIEW

The primary advantage to adopting a CRM system is that it provides a single platform for managing all your business data.

Graduate from spreadsheet hell to a centralised source of truth with all required information at your fingertips.

EXAMPLES

Store all your customers, products, etc. in the CRM

Customise every object type to feature the properties you need

Create associations to visualise object relationships

CUSTOMER INTERACTION TRACKING

REQUIRED

OVERVIEW

Extending your database with a complete history of customer interactions is fundamental to an effective CRM system.

Never forget what was discussed, shared, or agreed.

EXAMPLES

Synchronise your email inbox with the CRM system to keep track of the exchanges you had with your contacts

Log calls and meetings in the CRM system for convenient future reference

SALES PIPELINES MANAGEMENT

REQUIRED

OVERVIEW

Visually representing your sales pipeline is essential for any sales-oriented CRM system.

Gain immediate overview of what stage your leads currently reside in, and identify priorities or bottlenecks at a glance.

EXAMPLES

Set up and customise the pipelines in the CRM system to match your specific sales processes

Look for drag-and-drop functionality for intuitive opportunity progressing through your various pipelines

SIMPLICITY

OVERVIEW

There is no point in adopting a CRM system if nobody uses it. Make sure your solution is seamless to interact with and its data convenient to access.

Prioritise ease of use over fancy capabilities when choosing your software.

EXAMPLES

Focus on key functionality
that streamlines your sales operations

Design to reduce
administrative overhead

Use clear and consistent rules
throughout your CRM system architecture

INTEGRATIONS WITH YOUR OTHER TOOLS

OPTIONAL

OVERVIEW

Integrating the CRM system with your other business tools is a major advantage.

While not strictly necessary for a basic setup, integrations are the primary contributor to making your system seamless and convenient.

EXAMPLES

Connect your communication channels (mail, social media, websites, etc.)
to the CRM system
for direct sync and tracking

Integrate the CRM system
with your production management solutions
for smooth order handoff

WORKFLOW STANDAR-DISATION

OPTIONAL

OVERVIEW

Workflow standardisation refers to the wider set of CRM system features that help optimise daily operations.

Although not critical to system functionality, developing this aspect of the setup achieves major time savings and helps reduce human error.

EXAMPLES

Automate
repetitive manual processes

Create standard types and reminders
for recurring tasks

Introduce templates and FAQ resources
to standardise communications

REPORTING AND ANALYTICS

OPTIONAL

OVERVIEW

Funnelling company data through a single management platform provides the perfect foundation for meaningful analysis and reporting.

This can be leveraged both by management and the sales force to better understand and optimise business processes.

EXAMPLES

Track key performance metrics

Set up simple interfaces
for revenue tracking and forecasting

Automate report generation
for the data your team repeatedly needs

SCALABILITY

OPTIONAL

OVERVIEW

A well-adopted CRM system is an integral part of your business, and businesses rarely stagnate.

So why shoot yourself in the foot and spend resources on setting up a system that will not be able to adapt with you?

EXAMPLES

Ensure your CRM system can support increases in data volume and changes in business processes

Check for hidden costs: free small-scale software can quickly turn costly as your operations scale

CRM SYSTEM IMPLEMENTATION PRACTICES

REVIEW SALES PROCESSES

REQUIRED

OVERVIEW

Choosing to implement a CRM system presents a prime opportunity to review existing business processes.

Map out your current workflows and carefully consider how a CRM system would support them.

EXAMPLES

Clearly define and document current work processes

Establish sales pipelines with precise stage logic

Standardise, reuse, and simplify wherever possible

SET CLEAR GOALS

REQUIRED

OVERVIEW

CRM system adoption can be deceptively complex, easily resulting in major revisions of business operations and indefinitely extended deadlines.

Clearly define what, how, and when you want to achieve with the project.

EXAMPLES

Consider what CRM system features are needed for the challenges you face

Set priorities for what is urgent, and what can wait

Create a structured implementation roadmap with deliverables and deadlines

START SMALL EXPAND LATER

REQUIRED

OVERVIEW

Feature bloat is an underestimated problem.

It can be very tempting to make use of all the advanced functionality your CRM system has to offer, but this quickly adds complexity that makes the underlying systems confusing and unusable.

EXAMPLES

Start with establishing key functionality: if your foundations prove operational, you can always expand on them later

Do not try to tackle the whole implementation at once: allow users to get familiar with features before rolling out new ones

BE MINDFUL WITH YOUR DATA

OVERVIEW

A CRM system lives and breathes information. It also quickly accumulates large amounts of it.

Define clear data quality standards and governance rules to avoid messy databases with unusable data points.

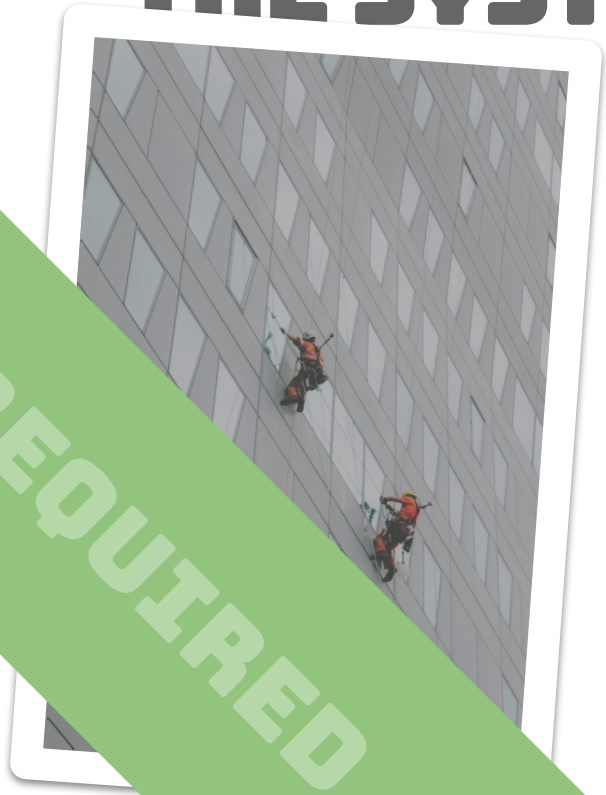
EXAMPLES

Define and enforce naming conventions across all data types in your CRM

Always prioritise defined field types over free-form text to keep things standardised and measurable

Consider introducing mandatory properties for when users create new records

MAINTAIN THE SYSTEM



REQUIRED

OVERVIEW

CRM system implementation is not a finite endeavour.

Considering that the tool becomes the central data management interface for the customer-facing processes of your business, it has to be kept in prime shape to ensure uninterrupted operation.

EXAMPLES

Your CRM system may be perfect,
but its operators may not be:
ensure proper onboarding for new users

Regularly review the architecture and data of your CRM system

Encourage and listen to user feedback for continuous optimisation

EVALUATE NEEDS

OPTIONAL

OVERVIEW

Before diving into process reviews and CRM-oriented optimisations, take a step back and consider if implementing a CRM system is truly required.

It is an advanced solution, and you may find it introduces more complexity to your operations than it provides help.

EXAMPLES

Consider that implementing a CRM system may require significant overhaul of your existing business processes

Identify your particular pain points and check for less complex solutions before committing to CRM system adoption

EVALUATE SOFTWARE

OPTIONAL

OVERVIEW

Although most CRM software offers the core functionality presented in this guide, it may excel at different aspects.

Consider various solutions and test their demo versions if available to identify the one best suited for your needs.

EXAMPLES

Evaluate up-front and long-term costs: consider SaaS versus bespoke software

Check product support capabilities: live assistance, implementation partners, user forums, online documentation, etc.

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